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A Congregational Doctrine of Vocation in Service to the Kingdom of God on Earth

Working English Machine Translation

Machine translation using Aaron Dahlen's

11-step translation process

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Note on Translation

This working English translation was produced by machine using Aaron Dahlen's 11-step translation process. The process uses artificial-intelligence language tools for transcription, translation, comparison, contextual analysis, and consistency checks against the original Norwegian text.

The resulting English text has not been independently or comprehensively edited by a human translator. The 11-step process is intended to improve the quality and traceability of machine translation, but it does not guarantee accuracy. Difficulties may remain, particularly in archaic language, idiom, historical terminology, and theological expression.

The original Norwegian text remains authoritative. This English text should therefore be treated as a machine-generated working translation rather than a critical or scholarly translation.

The subtitle and descriptive titles for Parts I–VI are editorial additions and do not appear in the original Norwegian text.

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1 Concerning the Lutheran Free Church and Its Tasks

1.1 What the Free Church Needs Most

Installment 1: “Folkebladet,” February 23, 1916

Most of us are surely aware that, if we are to make some progress toward the accomplishment of our task as a Free Church, the labor required for this will be both long and arduous.

I believe we do well to be clear that the Free Church is still in its formative stage. The goal is still far off. But even though we see the goal only from afar, we must not lose sight of it; rather, we must keep our gaze fixed upon it and continually set our course toward it. The conditions under which we labor to build a Free Church are by no means easy. And by this I am not thinking only of the fact that we are hemmed in between large, strong church bodies, with money and power and with long-established legitimacy and standing among our people.

I am also thinking of the materialistic spirit by which our age is so deeply marked. But if the calling and the task have been entrusted to us by the Lord, we have only one thing to do: to labor tirelessly and steadfastly toward the accomplishment of the task, whether the work seems easy or hard to us—according to the word of Scripture: “Let us do what is good and not grow weary; for we shall reap in due time, provided that we do not lose heart.”

For those who have grown to love the Lutheran Free Church in this country, and who therefore seek to take part in its work, it seems natural to me to ask: What is it that we especially need in order to labor purposefully toward the accomplishment of our task? And how can we, if possible, obtain what we need?

I know that many kinds of answers to these questions present themselves to our minds. It is natural, for example, to think of a seminary, much money, great and gifted leaders, and so forth.

Well, yes, it is true: we can never accomplish anything as a Free Church without a seminary, money, and men to lead the work.

But it is equally true that these and many other necessary things are not enough.

And what else—what more—do we need? There is a word from God that in former times was often heard among us, but which in more recent times we may have been in danger of forgetting: “Not by might, not by power, but by my Spirit, says the Lord.”

I will therefore answer the question of what we need most in this way: We need the Spirit—the Spirit of God. It is true that we also need much else, such as brotherly love, a sense of responsibility, and willingness to work.

But first and foremost, the Spirit of God.

We need the Spirit of God to bear witness to us that Jesus is our life—the life of the individual and of the congregation; and we need his guidance both to see the way and to receive strength to walk in it.

We need the help of the Spirit of God, through the word of Scripture, to come to a clear

understanding and full conviction that the position of the Free Church is biblical, and that the truths upon which it is built are the very word of Scripture. And the word of Scripture, despite every attack, stands unshaken.

In order to continue with confidence the church work that has been begun, we need full assurance that, so long as we are willing to walk the straight path—in accordance with the conviction and understanding we have gained from the New Testament’s presentation of congregational life—the Free Church too is unconquerable, despite all public opinion and all manifest enthusiasm for association.

I have not, however, meant by this to assert that we who today constitute the Lutheran Free Church are unconquerable. No, I am fully aware of our weakness and vulnerability, and that it may not be so difficult to cause us to drift in the struggle we have taken up, which many consider both unnecessary and hopeless.

But my thought is this: if we who now constitute the Free Church fail in our calling and our task, given to us by the Lord, and thus forfeit the blessing he has intended for us through this work, he will see to it that others arise, equipped with the light and power needed for the Free Church principle to be realized more and more, as God’s people gather around the free congregation as the right form of God’s kingdom on earth.

By this I do not mean to say that the ordering and work of denominational organizations have no value or legitimacy. On the contrary. I willingly acknowledge that within the church bodies there are congregations with believing members, and I also willingly acknowledge that a church body, by reason of its strong cohesion, has many favorable conditions for carrying out vigorous work, at least outwardly.

I mean only to say this: that we who belong to the association called the Lutheran Free Church and have learned to love it, belong there because we believe that the Lord, through the ecclesiastical development and ecclesiastical conflicts among Norwegian seekers after a church home in this country, has led us there, and because we believe that the New Testament points in that direction: free congregations joined together by “the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace.”

It is therefore also of exceedingly great importance for us that, under the guidance of the Spirit of God, we receive light concerning the greatness and beauty of our task—the bringing of the congregations to life and their liberation—and receive strength to walk the biblical path in our work of building congregations.

We need, in addition—especially in the Free Church, where no outward bonds exist to hold us together—brotherly love, so that we may be bound together as one, not by factional fences and constitution, not by formulas and laws, but by the strong, holy bond of brotherly love, so that it may be recognized and felt, both among ourselves and by others, that we are a family of brothers and sisters.

And we need a sense of responsibility, so that all of us—the individual friends of the Free Church and the individual congregations—continually live and labor under the consciousness that the Lutheran Free Church’s welfare, progress, or decline depends not first and foremost upon the relation of others to it, but upon my own relation to it—the relation of each

individual—and upon the relation of my—of our—congregation. Without some measure of such recognition and awareness, and the sense of responsibility that follows from it, it is surely hopeless to expect any future for the Free Church. And finally—and not least—we need willingness to work, so that we are willing to do something to build our church home.

We must, so far as possible, all take part in this work, so that each and every one of us, according to ability and gifts, endeavors to fill the place in which the Lord has set us, and there to do the work for him with eagerness, willingness, and joy.

1.2 How We Receive What We Need

Installment 2: “Folkebladet,” March 01, 1916

The question, then, is this: how can we come to share in these blessings, so glorious and indispensable as they are for us?

There may perhaps be one person or another who, without further thought, consoles himself with the belief that we possess them, and therefore need not concern ourselves with this matter, either for ourselves or for others.

I do not think, however, that very many think in this way. Most among us must surely acknowledge that we are unspeakably poor in spiritual life and in everything else that we so deeply need, both in our personal life of faith and in our congregational life.

We therefore feel the importance of the question: how can we receive what we need? It is perhaps not so easy to answer this question.

I believe, however, that many agree with me when, to begin with, I answer: We never receive these blessings and gifts against our will, nor do we receive them without doing something in order to receive them.

Yes, but what can we do? Perhaps not much; but we can do something, provided only that we are willing. We can, first of all, acknowledge our spiritual poverty and our lukewarmness. But this is by no means an easy road to walk. It costs humiliation and suffering, and from that we shrink.

I do not know for certain, but it may be that there has been some inclination among us to settle into complacency both with our own spiritual condition and with that of our congregations. Yes, that is dangerous.

Paul was never satisfied, either with his own relation to God or with that of the congregations. Always more, always farther onward: “I press on to lay hold of it”—“I hasten toward the goal.”

And he exhorts the congregations to which he writes his letters to do likewise: “You also, brothers, become imitators of me!” “Therefore I bow my knees before the Father . . . that he . . . may grant you to be strengthened with power through his Spirit in your inner being.”

Yes, if this deep acknowledgment of our powerlessness and our half-hearted Christianity could seize us, fill us! Then there would be cries for help, and then we would receive help.

To his first congregation Jesus said: “You will receive power when the Holy Spirit comes upon you, and you will be my witnesses both in Jerusalem and to the ends of the earth.”

And of this congregation it is written: “They continued with one accord in prayer.” And they continued in this prayer with one accord until, on the day of Pentecost, they received the power from on high.

He who alone can give us what we most need, also in our Free Church work—he has said to us as well: “Ask, and you will receive!” We can, if we are willing, acknowledge our helplessness and need and lament them before the Lord. We can tell him at least something about what is lacking—not first and foremost in others, but in ourselves, both individually and as congregations.

Certainly he knows it well, he who says, “I know your works,” without our telling him; but he has nevertheless laid down in his word the rule that spiritual blessing reaches neither the individual nor the congregation without earnest prayer. And here, no doubt, lies our great loss: We pray so little, both in the private chamber and in the congregational gathering. I know well that believing people can never cease praying altogether; but I also know that the heart can grow cold, the knees stiff, and prayer many a time become only a prayer for ourselves.

Brothers and sisters, let us attend to this matter. For it is so important.

The kingdom of God that Jesus brought was not intended to be merely a Christianity of individuals. It was intended to be a Christianity of fellowship, in the sense in which we confess in the Third Article: “I believe in the communion of saints.”

It is certainly true that it is as individuals that we come to share in salvation and enter into union with God; but it is not intended that each believer should live his life in God for himself alone, but rather that he should live this life in the blessed consciousness of belonging among the Lord’s great company of children.

According to the New Testament, there can be no mistaking that it is God’s will and purpose that his people should live their life in God as a life in fellowship. Therefore so much is said about “fellowship.”

And Jesus prays for his own that “they may be one” with almost greater earnestness than for anything else.

We may therefore conclude that, for him, this matter has overwhelmingly great importance. Yes, he himself says that he prays for this “so that the world may believe that you have sent me.”

The progress and spread of Christianity depend upon this.

It is therefore important to think of the congregation and the congregations when the question is how we are to receive the gifts of grace without which the Free Church cannot be built. And when it concerns the manner in which these gifts may be obtained, the way is not simply the same for the individual as for the congregation. For the individual, perhaps one of the most important things required in order to receive these gifts is that solitude be sought.

For the congregation, on the other hand, what is required, as already pointed out, is that fellowship be sought—the communion of saints.

Even after the outpouring of the Spirit, it is said of the first Christians: “They held faithfully to the apostles’ teaching and to the fellowship, to the breaking of bread and to the prayers.” Acts 2:42.

They therefore found it necessary to gather with one another in such assemblies, where love for one another and love for the Lord and his cause were the sole command impelling them to gather.

Concerning this matter, the late Professor Sverdrup says in *Collected Writings*, volume 3, page 307:

If free, independent congregations are not to lose something of the power of cooperation, spiritual connection is needed. Free cooperation in everything that can serve the advancement of God’s kingdom at home and abroad is necessary. If it is to take place, then we must understand one another and know one another. We must exchange thoughts and spirit and thus have the bonds of love tied in the freedom of the Spirit. As far as I can understand, genuine Free Church work will be almost impossible under our conditions without a great many free meetings and gatherings.

As may be seen from these statements by Professor Sverdrup, he placed great weight upon the people of the Free Church coming together for free meetings.

And it is a well-known fact among us that quite a number of such larger or smaller meetings are also held, at which it is desired that brothers and sisters from several congregations should gather. This is both necessary and right; for we shall scarcely be supplied in any other way with that power from on high which we must have, if we are to be able to fulfill our task, than by gathering for such meetings.

But I, and perhaps many with me, have observed with concern that the felt need to come together for annual meetings, mission meetings, district meetings, and so forth seems to be declining to an alarming degree. What can be the cause? Could it perhaps be the same cause for which the congregation and the angel of the congregation in Laodicea had to hear these solemn words: “Because you say, ‘I am rich and have abundance and lack nothing,’ and you do not know that you are wretched and pitiable and poor and blind and naked, I therefore counsel you to buy from me—”?

Oh, let us follow his counsel: “buy from him.”

1.3 What Our Meetings Are For

Installment 3: “Folkebladet,” March 08, 1916

There could be much to say about the reason why our meetings are less well attended than before; but I shall pass over that this time and look somewhat at our meetings as we generally have them.

At times the thought has taken hold of me that our meetings are not always what they ought to be. And on this account the question has arisen: what is the deficiency, or what are the deficiencies, in several of our meetings?

As will be understood, I proceed from the assumption that we intend something, that we will something, when we hold meetings.

For it is also conceivable that meetings may be held without anything real being intended by them.

But what is it, then, that we will?

The answer may perhaps be given: we wish, if possible, to derive some profit for faith and thought. We intend that the individual, through the word and the Spirit, may come nearer to God. Among other things, we intend through our meetings that those who gather may be influenced by the truth toward a deeper recognition of sin and guilt before God, and toward a more childlike and trusting appropriation of grace, of salvation.

And finally, we intend to impart Christian knowledge, deeper insight into the Lord's word and the Lord's plan of salvation for the individual and for the congregation, and a clearer understanding of our life and of the task we have been set to accomplish here in life. In a word: we would so gladly be made partakers of a greater fullness of God's Spirit.

As may be seen, the goal here set as the result of a meeting is rather high. But not too high. It is not unattainable, even though it is not easy to reach. Yet the difficulty involved in attaining this high goal ought neither to frighten us away from holding such meetings nor, in faintheartedness, cause us to lower the demand or comfort ourselves with the cheap consolation that it matters little whether the goal is reached or not.

No, let the high goal stand before our thought and our longing in all its beauty and greatness; and let us, with all the means God himself has entrusted to us, labor and pray that it may be attained.

The truth is, namely, that it can be attained. For of all that is certain, nothing is more certain than this, that "the Lord holds his people dear." No gift is the Lord more willing to give his people than the gift of the Spirit. And when his people gather as children around their Father's table to be sanctified and made fit for their work for him, the Lord is willing to bless.

It is, however, a fact that the experience of many concerning the profit of such meetings is this: that it has often been so small. And by profit I do not mean primarily the more or less powerful stirring which, for many, is the only profit they desire. No, I think rather of what is called spirit in a meeting, of whether we succeed in leading one another deeper into the word, and finally of the abiding effects of the word spoken during the meeting.

What, then, is the reason that the profit is so often so small? What is the reason that many of our meetings are so ineffectual, so poor in spirit and in profit for the participants?

The causes are no doubt many, perhaps. And I do not presume to think that I possess the ability to point out all the hindering causes on account of which several of our meetings bear

so little fruit. But if I could succeed in drawing the attention of our Free Church people to this matter, and if I could moreover point out some of these hindering causes and, if possible, do ever so little toward their removal, the purpose of these words would be attained.

There are certain things in connection with our larger meetings that I wish to mention, but I am uncertain which I should mention first. I therefore point to the hindrances I believe I see in the order in which they present themselves to my thought.

The first great deficiency in at least most of our meetings, I believe, is this: they are far too little prepared through prayer.

I know well that some who read this will object that this is not so, but that believers, prior to the holding of a meeting, pray for God's blessing upon it. Yes, at almost all the meetings I have attended, I myself have heard speakers say that they have asked the Lord to "save, if only one soul, at the meeting." And this, then, is supposed to be proof that the meeting has been well prepared through prayer? To such a claim I will say, quietly but firmly: no!

For in the first place, very few of those who pray for a meeting intend anything definite by their prayer. They pray because they believe it is their duty to do so. Or, if they do intend something by their prayer, there are many who do not know what they intend. And how, then, can God answer such a prayer?

There are no doubt those who will contradict me here also and answer that they both intend something and know what they intend. For, they say, we ask the Lord to save the unsaved, and we pray that God's children may be edified; and then surely we must intend something and know what it is we intend.

Well, yes, I myself have many times prayed in the same manner, but I fear that, nevertheless, I have not truly been clear about what I was asking. What is meant when in prayer we say to God: you must save sinners at this meeting?

I assume that the very great majority who pray in this manner think chiefly of a spiritual stirring perceptible to everyone during the meeting, especially among those who were assumed until then to have been indifferent.

Yes, someone says, but is this not good?

Yes, of course it is. And more than once during the time in which I have taken part in meetings, I myself have experienced the great joy of witnessing such a stirring. And yet—it is not decisive.

Spiritual stirring is not synonymous with "being saved." What is decisive—the fact that a soul in its inmost being turns from the world and sin to God—is not proved by an hour of emotional stirring during a meeting. The stirring that is perceived may be deep and true, but it may also be superficial and deceptive.

It is therefore not certain that all who pray that a "soul may be saved" during the meeting are thinking of, and truly know, what they are asking. They may pray earnestly and mean well, but they do not think deeply enough, not biblically enough. For as a rule, by the expression "the salvation of a soul," one thinks only of being allowed, at the meeting, to witness one or

more persons, with tears and perhaps with a request for intercession, show openly that they have been seized by the effect of the word. And this—as already said—is good and well so far as it reaches. But with many, with most, it does not reach far enough.

Salvation, or perhaps more properly, being made a partaker of salvation, is something else and something more—not merely religious moods, not merely anguish over having acted foolishly, and still less terror of hell, but the heart’s surrender to God, the will at rest in harmony with his will, so that the sinner in the inmost depth of his being says: “I will rise and go to my Father.”

By this I have not said that we should not desire and pray for spiritual stirring during a meeting. No, we can hardly have too much of it—at least not of that stirring which is brought about by a living and Spirit-filled proclamation of God’s word.

For it is a truth confirmed by experience that the word most often makes its way through feeling to the will.

There may, of course, be such natures whose life of the will is best influenced through thought, but they are exceptions, not the rule. Therefore let us rejoice that spiritual stirring is perceptible during a meeting, but let us not overvalue it.

1.4 What True Edification Is

Installment 4: “Folkebladet,” March 15, 1916

Through the little I have said here about this matter, I have tried to indicate how indefinite and how lacking in a clear aim it is when prayer is offered for “salvation” for a soul.

And I believe that the same is true when prayer is offered for “edification for the believers.” For what is commonly meant by the expression “edification” is that the single person—the individual—may during the meeting be brought into a pleasant feeling of joy and satisfaction with himself or with his Christianity. In other words: joy and a sense of happiness in being a believer, in contrast to “the world.”

Now I do not mean to say that joy over salvation is unwarranted and harmful. On the contrary. I maintain, with God’s Word, that “joy in the Lord is our strength.” But in the first place, it is far from true that “joy in the Lord” is the same as a feeling of pleasant satisfaction with oneself and one’s conversion. No, “joy in the Lord” is the soul’s blessed rest—not in its repentance, conversion, faith, or sanctification, but in the completed salvation through Jesus Christ—procured for all, but received and availed of only by those who bow themselves to God with an undivided mind.

Now it is essentially true that the soul which “believes,” which receives in Jesus Christ salvation from sin and perdition, possesses something that “the world” does not. It is true that where surrender to God has taken place, a great change has occurred—the greatest that can happen to a human being. But this change, by which a person becomes willing to receive salvation, is a work of God himself through his Spirit and Word—a work which the Spirit has accomplished amid much resistance and many hindrances on our part.

“Joy in the Lord” cannot, therefore, be joy over the fact that “I have been converted,” but joy that salvation has been procured for me through Jesus’ atoning death; and when, through the Spirit’s guidance and working, I have learned to make it my own, to rest in it, and to build my whole blessedness upon it—then I possess something of the joy in the Lord. But the others—“the world”—can also receive a share in this “salvation.” For “God wills that all people should be saved and come to the knowledge of the truth.”

That the believers are edified is not the same as being confirmed in the thought that I am so thoroughly converted, or that in my heart I am certain that, if everyone were like me, all would be well in the world. No, “edification” is that, through the working of the Word, I am made to see how poor a Christian I am, how meager both faith and life are—in other words: that my knowledge of sin is deepened, my gratitude to God for salvation increased, and my zeal for the salvation of others made more ardent.

“Edification,” therefore, is this: that I receive more of the mind of Jesus, so that for me, as for him, it becomes “my food,” the wealth and happiness of my life, the secret fountain of joy in my soul, to be permitted to fight in self-denial, to take part in the Lord’s army in the battle against the evil within us—and around us.

But if this is the true “edification” of the believer, it is easy to understand that not very many are inclined to desire it, to pray for it. For it is costly. It costs humiliation, sacrifice, money.

Jesus says: “Take my yoke upon you and learn from me, for I am gentle and humble in heart, and you will find rest for your souls: for my yoke is beneficial and my burden is light.”

Here he says, therefore, that “his yoke” is the soul’s rest; that edification, rest for the soul, is obtained by taking “his yoke,” by learning from him to labor for his cause with something of that mind to which it is “food to do the Father’s will.”

Whether we will admit it or not, it is nevertheless true that we are all tempted to settle ourselves comfortably on earth and to trouble ourselves as little as possible about the crying need in which our brothers in the world find themselves. The “edification” which we here, as God’s people, most need when we gather around his Word at our larger or smaller meetings is this: that we receive more desire and more strength to walk fearlessly on our fixed way, in that life whose wealth and happiness are the joyful self-sacrifice for Jesus Christ’s great, world-liberating task; so that concerning us also the familiar but often forgotten word may become reality, may become truth: “As he is, so are we in this world.”

My meaning, therefore, is that the believers have received true edification during a meeting when they leave the meeting with deeper sorrow over their own powerlessness and wretchedness, with a firmer resolve to cling to grace more childlike and trustfully, and with a more burning longing to be among the ranks of those who have gone out to conquer the world for Christ. The believers are edified when, through the working of the Word, they leave a meeting fully conscious that they, in the one journey they have through life, will follow Jesus Christ.

It will, of course, cost—perhaps much: “And he said to all: If anyone wishes to come after me, he must deny himself and every day take up his cross and follow me. For whoever wishes to save his life will lose it, but whoever loses his life for my sake, he will save it.”

And it may indeed happen that the heart will at times writhe in pain over what it will cost.
But nevertheless—the same heart that found salvation in Jesus says to him in full earnest:

Hymn reference: Hymnary.org, “Din, O Jesus, din at være” by Theodor Wilhelm Oldenburg.

Editorial note: E.B. quotes stanzas 1 and 4 of this hymn. Because the complete hymn would have been familiar within the Norwegian Lutheran context of the period, stanzas 2, 3, and 5 are supplied here to restore the context available to the original reader.

1

Yours, O Jesus, yours to be,
Is my joy and all my honor,
Yours in life and yours in death;
Therefore I will struggle onward,
In your footsteps I will journey,
Finding sweet the hour of battle.

2

Yes, I know that only he can
Find the crown of glory with you,
Glory’s crown and peace of life,
Who, despite all dangers of life,
All the foe’s deceit and darkness,
Faithfully walks in your steps.

3

Underneath the cross I’ll enter,
Bearing it with quiet gladness,
That cross, Savior, which is yours;
Though my path leads through dark valleys,
Still my goal in heaven’s dwelling
I behold with joyful eyes.

4

Lead me where death itself threatens,
Lead me through affliction’s fire,
Through the storm upon the wild sea;
As you will, O dearest Jesus,
If only you, yes, you will be
My own strong supporting staff.

5

Shining in the light of your grace,
Lead me on the road toward the goal

While I wander here on earth;
And when all the cross is ended,
Let me enter into heaven,
Where you dwell in glorious light.

And while we, according to the grace we receive, fight the fight against ourselves and our own wretchedness and against the evil in the world around us, our heart is lifted up in blessed joy at possessing God's unchangeable love in Christ, and we count everything as loss, if only we may keep it. And he himself has taught us that when the battle has been fought to its end and the way of the cross in following him here in this foreign land has been traversed, we will then accompany him into the land of perfection and there be together with him through the long, joy-bringing "Sabbath rest that remains for God's people."

"Where I am, there my servant will also be."

1.5 Preparing for the Work

Installment 5: "Folkebladet," March 22, 1916

Besides what I pointed out in my previous article, another matter may also be mentioned in connection with intercessory prayer for a meeting: our prayer, and perhaps especially our intercession, is often so powerless, so little heaven-storming and heartfelt.

So often there is lacking that intensity and persistence with which we pray for ourselves when our soul has been struck by some grievous distress. Then we pray because we want something, because we desire something from God.

And if we were clear-sighted enough to see what is at stake—the dreadful ravaging of sin in the world, the threatening advance of the enemy—then intercession for our meetings, which we expect to be a battlefield where the powers of darkness and light meet in combat, would also become far more a cry of distress to the Lord and would bring victory from him.

Yet another matter may also be pointed out in this connection: united prayer, congregational prayer. It is scarcely ever practiced among us. Yes, someone says, when we are gathered for a prayer meeting, several of us pray for blessing upon the approaching edification meeting or mission meeting.

Now, yes, that is well and good where it is done. For not even this is practiced everywhere. But there may nevertheless be little true united prayer in it. It may be such, but it may also be only individual prayer, the prayer of single persons, and nothing more. For in the prayer for "blessing upon the meeting," one person may have one thing in mind and another something entirely different. By united prayer for a meeting I mean particularly this: that a congregation has a living recognition of what it especially needs to receive from the Lord, and that it therefore, as one heart and one soul, longs to obtain this and therefore asks it of him in prayer.

"Again I say to you: Whatever two of you on earth agree to ask for, it shall be given them by my Father in heaven. For where two or three are gathered in my name, there I am in the midst of them."

And concerning the apostles before the day of Pentecost it is said:

“They went up into the upper room, where they were staying—Peter and John and James and Andrew, Philip and Thomas, Bartholomew and Matthew, James the son of Alphaeus, and Simon the Zealot, and Judas the son of James. All these continued with one accord in prayer, together with some women and Mary, the mother of Jesus, and his brothers.”

Here we have true united prayer, the prayer that brings blessing, help from God. And for my part I am certain that if more prayer of this kind were practiced before our meetings, these would prove a greater blessing than they now often are.

Could we only remember vividly that the same Lord who has promised to hear prayer when two agree to pray for victory from God over evil—that he stretches out his nail-pierced hands toward human beings and says, “When I am lifted up from the earth, I will draw all to myself”—there would surely be more seriousness in our intercession. The conclusion, then, at which I arrive in the question of preparing our meetings by prayer is this: either no prayer at all is offered, or, if it is offered by one person or another, it is done with so little definite purpose that an answer from God to the prayer can scarcely be expected.

Certainly it is true that “it is God who works in us both to will and to accomplish,” so that our most heartfelt prayer, and that wrestling of the soul with him in which it is said, “I will not let you go until you bless me,” are also his work. Yet, in spite of this, he wills that we should pray with such earnestness as though the blessing of a meeting depended exclusively upon our prayer. But why can prayer be so significant when it too is his own impulse and work in us, brought forth by the Spirit?

My answer to this question is that our prayer means nothing other than that we are willing to receive the help and the blessing which the Lord, in free, unmerited grace, so gladly desires to give us, and which we so sorely need. If our soul has not been so deeply struck by our own and others’ spiritual distress that we ask him with full earnestness for deliverance in that distress, then this is the clearest sign that at bottom we see no danger and therefore do not care about deliverance from God in the distress. Then we shall never receive it. For salvation from sin and spiritual powerlessness is so great that it can be received only by a heart so pressed by this distress that, in comparison with it, it desires nothing else:

“Whom have I in heaven? And when I have you, I desire nothing on earth!”

In this cry we encounter the gathered mind, the undivided heart, for which salvation has become an overwhelmingly great reality, and which therefore partakes of it in so rich a measure.

What I intended by the little I have said here was, then, this: to point out a deficiency which, in my judgment, is so common at our larger meetings, namely, that as a rule they are far too little prepared for by united prayer, congregational prayer. And could I bring individual believers and our congregations to begin thinking over and considering this matter and, if possible, to take it more seriously, I should be deeply glad.

Another very common deficiency at most of our larger meetings is that those who are to take part by giving testimony often speak vaguely, unclearly, and without any aim.

And one of the most common causes of this is that the person concerned is unprepared. That is to say: the person has not studied the Word of God or the subject that is to be treated during the meeting.

But the natural consequence is that in such a case the speaker either does not speak on the text at all, or, if he keeps within the framework of the text, speaks so generally, so vaguely, and with so little point that the hearers are simply bored. And this ought not to be so when the word that is read is “spirit and life.” The Bible says: “Whoever speaks should speak as one who speaks words of God.” And God’s Word concerning the way of salvation is not religious phrases, but clear, definite, concrete truths about sin and guilt before God and about salvation from sin through Jesus Christ. And God’s Word also contains clear, definite truths concerning the life in God which his child is to live here on earth.

Therefore the testimony borne by layman or pastor during a meeting should consist of definite truths drawn from the subject or passage of Scripture that is being treated. No one has the right to excuse himself here with the often-repeated claim that one “has not had time to prepare.” For the one who has had no time for any preparation should not take part by giving testimony. If the matter concerning which we gather for a meeting is not so important that it drives us to as good and thorough a preparation as possible, it is better not to take up any of the meeting’s brief, precious time as a speaker. But not only the one who is to speak at a meeting should prepare himself. The one who is to hear should do the same: prepare himself through prayer and through consideration of the Word of God that is to be treated. By this means the benefit to the hearers would in every case be greater than it otherwise is.

The one who is to speak at a meeting should at least have some grasp of what the word on which he is to speak contains, and he should be able to set forth with reasonable clarity truths contained in the subject before him. Those who come to the meeting to hear have a right to expect this, and many of them really do expect it.

The time should at least be past when, at meetings such as those intended here, one can serve up old, familiar, assorted religious phrases without coherence and without any connection whatever with the subject of the meeting. Certainly this can still be done, and unfortunately it is probably done far too often; but the effects, the fruit, correspond to it. It is therefore careless and irresponsible when someone travels to a meeting to take part by giving testimony without having made any attempt to prepare himself. What would one say of the soldier who went into battle without having inspected his weapons and without having practiced using them? He would at least be able to accomplish little for the king or general in whose army he was to fight against the enemy.

And to take part by giving testimony at a meeting is to enter a holy war. It is to enter war against the prince of darkness and “the spiritual host of wickedness under heaven.”

Paul presents every Christian’s life here on earth as military service. He says:

“Stand, then, with truth girded about your loins and clothed with the breastplate of righteousness, and with your feet shod with the readiness that the gospel of salvation gives; and besides all this, take up the shield of faith, with which you shall be able to quench all the burning arrows of the evil one, and take the helmet of salvation and the sword of the Spirit,

which is God's Word."

And then people will accuse Paul of not understanding what Christianity is.

But if this applies to Christians in general, then it applies to preachers in particular. For such men are not merely rank-and-file soldiers; they should be leaders, officers in Christ's victorious army on earth. And where the armor and weapons are lacking or are not used, we need not wonder at the unsuccessful result of the battle.

None of us, therefore, should go to a meeting with the thought of accomplishing something for our Lord's great cause without serious preparation through heartfelt prayer and a conscientious effort to penetrate the Word of God or the subject that is to be treated during the meeting.

1.6 What result are we seeking?

Installment 6: "Folkebladet," March 29, 1916

And here no one among us should shrink back from the labor and exertion that such preparation requires. For it repays us well in our own spiritual development and in our fitness for battle against the enemy. If we truly desire that our participation in the Lord's fighting army should yield some result, should be something other and more than a "beating of the air," then preparation is necessary—regardless of what it costs in toil, labor, and prayer. I know very well that we can obtain recognition, and perhaps even praise, from some people without laboring with great exertion to find our own way into the word and without seeking to lead our hearers into it. For what some seek to obtain as the yield of a meeting is that the emotional life of the soul should in some way be set in motion. And the preacher who speaks in such a manner that this is attained often receives praise from superficial persons. But everyone knows that such results can easily be attained without preparation and without prayer—and many are tempted to be satisfied with such things. This, however, is not, and should never be, what we aim at when we participate in a meeting by bearing testimony. Human praise or human blame should have little influence upon us. Our calling is to set our honor in "holding Jesus Christ forth to view," whether this brings us censure or recognition. For what is worth more than human praise or human blame is to receive a friendly, approving glance from him, our great and exalted king, in whose army we have enlisted and under whose banner of the cross we fight.

But his approval is never gained by fighting with self-made weapons, nor by seeking honor for ourselves.

Another matter to which I would also gladly point, because in my judgment it is so significant, is that the person who participates in a meeting should have an aim and a plan for his testimony: an aim, so that he intends something, and a plan, so that he pursues his aim.

We need not listen long to the testimony of some before it becomes clear to us that, at bottom, they aim at nothing and particularly desire nothing, except perhaps this: to speak for the sake of speaking.

That this is wrong should be evident to everyone. And the person who intends nothing by his speech should never occupy the meeting's time. There are others who speak, and in whose

testimony it can plainly be perceived that they do intend something. There are spirit and fire in them.

But what do they intend?

Some of them are almost offended by such a question and answer with indignation: What do we intend? We intend awakening. We intend that the people to whom we speak should be awakened. Yes, is this, then, not right? Certainly it is. And I rejoice every time that, in a meeting, I am permitted to hear a testimony borne forth by a heart filled with a burning desire that those who sleep may be awakened.

For awakening is continually needed, so long as the evil powers in the world wind their creeping courses around human beings.

The individual and the Lord's congregation need awakening—such seasons of breakthrough in which life is renewed and made effective. And I will never join those who would dampen the zeal of those whose testimony aims at awakening.

No, let the word of awakening sound forth with clarity and power in our meetings! For the winter cold and the sleepiness are easily perceived everywhere. And when those who long for the manifestations of spring's life, for the disappearance of the night—those whose eyes are weary from watching for the morning and wet with tears from sorrow over themselves and their brothers and sisters in the world—when such persons, with burning and throbbing hearts, speak for awakening in a meeting, then I rejoice. And from my innermost heart I desire that God may bless all those who are grieved over the spiritual distress among our people, and who therefore lament and long, pray and labor, testify and act, that awakening may come! For as a rule it comes only through labor, sacrifice, and prayer. But even if it comes, even if—as I have already pointed out—there arises some more or less powerful spiritual movement, and even if one or more persons indicate that they desire intercessory prayer and guidance, it is not enough. And the testimony that aims only at awakening, only at movement, is imperfect and one-sided.

Spiritual movement, where it is genuine, is only a promising beginning, and nothing more. The apple blossom in spring is beautiful; that is true. But the blossom is not thereby a guarantee of fruit. What is decisive is the summer and the harvest. Then it will become evident whether the blossom became more than a promising possibility. So it is also in the world of the Spirit. Awakening may be promising, but it is not the same as conversion and life in God.

But at times the spiritual stirrings and movements produced by a testimony in a meeting are not even genuine. The movement may be only a superficial intoxication that results in nothing, or in something worse than nothing: it makes the person harder and less receptive to the truth than before. It is therefore so important that the person who speaks for awakening in a meeting should set as his aim that the souls whom he seeks to reach through his testimony should be affected not only in their emotional life, but also in their volitional life, so that, through the working of God's Spirit by means of the word, there may be conversion, change of mind, and new life in God. Only then has the testimony produced the effect that it ought to have.

It has been shown, not once but many times, that great movements in a meeting fulfilled very little of what they promised. The change of mind that appeared to be traceable in several persons lasted, in many cases, no longer than until the end of the emotionally charged meeting. And then it is certain that the very testimony that was spoken was not what it ought to have been.

The Lord's word now, as before, has power in itself to recreate human hearts, so that it may truthfully be said of them: "The old has passed away; behold, all has become new."

And where the Lord's truth is spoken by living, Spirit-filled witnesses in a meeting prepared and conducted under earnest prayer, it will always bear its blessed fruit, even though no greater awakening is perceived.

For the highest fruit a meeting can bear is that believers are awakened. Someone may perhaps say that believers are awake. Yes, perhaps they are. But they can fall asleep again: "When the bridegroom delayed, they all slumbered and fell asleep." And therefore they continually need to be awakened further—awakened to see their own dullness and the great spiritual peril of their fellow human beings. It may indeed be that the greatest obstacle to the kingdom of God, to "the salvation of souls," is the half-hearted, powerless godliness of those who confess Christ. Is it not a truth established by experience, yet deeply humiliating, that our dear Savior has often offered us an opportunity to "take up the cross," but—we declined?

It did not escape the attention of him whose solicitous gaze is fixed upon us and who asks with concern: "Will you also go away?"

And perhaps it did not escape the attention of those who expect us to be "the light of the world," and who can be won for Jesus Christ only through the testimony given by the life of God's congregation—the life lived in voluntary renunciation and suffering, and in continual, self-forgetting labor for his cause. Christ has never, through the baptism of blood upon the cross, given his life for the salvation of the world so that we should discuss religious questions, attend festivals or meetings in order to enjoy ourselves, and otherwise remain as inconspicuous as possible—"laying up treasures upon earth."

No, what is needed in order that the fire may be kindled of which Jesus said, "Fire I have come to cast upon the earth, and how gladly I would have it already kindled," is that God's congregation should awaken—should see its own danger and the danger of others, and should be penetrated throughout by an "unceasing pain" over the distress of our people and by a glad, battle-ready spirit of conquest whose aim is to win our people for Christ. And where such results are attained through a meeting, there God's Spirit, who is the true power able to produce awakening, has been at work through the word, even though no tumultuous movement could be perceived.

For the awakening of believers most commonly takes place in such a manner—at the beginning, at least—that no one other than the Lord and the individual soul awakened by the word's sharp rebuke knows anything of it.

This will, of course, soon be perceived by others as well, since the believer's outward life and work will bear the mark of the renewal and enrichment of godliness.

2 The kingdom of heaven is like a householder who went out to hire laborers for his vineyard.

(E. B.)

“Folkebladet,” April 05, 1916

If we attentively try to study the parables or images which Jesus uses in order to present the kingdom of heaven, the kingdom of God, we shall become aware that he very often uses such parables in which this kingdom is presented as work, as activity. And when we look upon his own life here on earth, we cannot avoid becoming aware that he was continually at work, and he was so glad in his work that he even calls it his “food to do the Father’s will.”

It is true that he promises rest to those who come to him, but this never means, as many seem to think, an existence consisting in feeling good, having things easy, and being inactive. No, the rest he promises his own is rest from the unrest of heart and conscience on account of sin. It is the rest which consists in being able, with childlike confidence and blessed joy, to cry: Abba, Father. That rest Jesus gives. But he gives it in order that through it we may receive strength, will, desire, and an inward urge to do something for him.

Jesus himself was no lazy Christian. “He went about doing good,” and the last word he spoke to those who had attached themselves to him was this: “Go into all the world and preach the gospel to all creation.”

In the preaching of God’s word which has now sounded among us for nearly a generation, most has been said about “sin and grace.” And however right and proper and necessary such preaching is, there is nevertheless a deficiency in it. This we can see so clearly from Jesus’ preaching. He too spoke about sin and grace, but he also spoke much—no, most—about works. Look for yourself, and you will be convinced. The reason that our preaching has dwelt almost exclusively upon this great theme, “sin and grace,” is closely grounded in two things. On the one hand, there is the distance we have taken from, and the fear we have acquired of, “dead orthodoxy,” “pure doctrine” without asking after life; and on the other hand, the awakening, partly that by which many of us were more or less seized when we came from Norway, and partly that which passed like a thaw over our people and our congregations some thirteen to twenty years ago. And perhaps also—and not least—the position into which we have come among the Norwegian Lutheran church people here in this country.

Our program has indeed been, and is: the quickening and liberation of the congregations. And quickening and liberation the Lord alone can give to the individual and to his congregation. Therefore it is so natural that the preaching among us has sounded approximately as it is set forth in the programmatic explanation “Seek the Lord,” which by some has been so mercilessly criticized.

For my own part, I have reservations about passing judgment as to whether the criticism mentioned was justified, but I am inclined to hold the opinion that the criticism in question was, at least in part, badly applied. But even if we are clear that the kind of preaching here mentioned is both justified and necessary, and that it is moreover, so to speak, a matter of course among us who have all been more or less influenced by the religious outlook and

understanding of the congregation held by the late Prof. Georg Sverdrup, this does not exclude the possibility that there may be one or more deficiencies in it. And I am inclined to believe that perhaps in our preaching in the Free Church we have laid too little weight upon encouraging one another to “love and good works.” It is therefore necessary that we return to this matter again and again, lest we forget it.

Our course as believing individuals and congregations is a course into work—not into self-chosen rest in inactivity.

And that Jesus attaches the greatest importance to this matter we see clearly from his portrayal of the last great day of reckoning, when the King shall determine who shall enter the kingdom and who shall be sent away. Then it is precisely what has been neglected or what has been done that has significance and is decisive.

The work particularly in view here is the more directly Christian work, the work for the salvation of souls and the building up of God’s congregation. And with these expressions our thoughts are at once directed toward what is called mission, foreign mission and home or inner mission.

Some will certainly object that not everyone can take part in that work, that not everyone can go out as missionaries abroad or at home. Yes, that is true. Not everyone can go out, and by no means has everyone received a call to do so. But nevertheless everyone can take part.

In nearly every place among our congregations, work for mission is carried on partly by the congregation as such, and partly by societies within it: mission societies, women’s societies, young people’s societies, children’s societies, and so forth. And anyone whatever can join these societies. Moreover, subscription lists are, so to speak, continually sent out among us, in which contributions are requested for one or another of our common undertakings.

None of us therefore needs to excuse himself by saying that we have no opportunity to do anything. The opportunity we have, but whether we have the will is another matter. Yet there is One of whom it is written that he works in us both to will and to do according to his good pleasure. And if only he is allowed to rule in our heart and our life, we shall become warmer and more zealous friends of our home mission and foreign mission as the days pass and as we consider that many of us, at least, have come far on in the day of our life.

It will become with us as with Paul: for me to live is Christ. He becomes the One whom you desire to please and to whom you desire to be acceptable, the One in whose service you count it your honor and find your joy.

And this inward impulse toward work is the work of the Spirit of God in you. There is certainly much that will hinder us in this work. But he who has appointed us to his service has also given us his gifts in order that we may be made complete for the work of ministry.

In this way it is that the congregation, which is the body of Christ, advances more and more toward the form it is appointed to have, and becomes a means of salvation for the world in which it is set as the light upon the lampstand and the city upon the hill.

Can this goal be reached? Yes, but not until it becomes clear to all true members of the congregation that their calling is work, the work of service, and until they are willing to

follow the call.

Here lies the difficulty also in the question of solving the common task we have, which is called our home mission. It will never be solved in the way it ought to be so long as our congregations and individual friends push the thought of it and the responsibility for it away from themselves and seek to quiet their conscience with the consolation that, when they work for foreign mission and the school for pastors, others can take care of this petty business called home mission. No, the one ought to be done, and the other not neglected.

3 Why Does the Lutheran Free Church Attempt to Carry On Home Mission Work?

“Folkebladet,” April 26, 1916

E. B.

To this question there can no doubt be various answers, since the question may be viewed and judged from several sides.

The first answer, and the one which seems to me the most immediate, is this: The Lutheran Free Church attempts to carry on home mission work—as well as foreign mission—because it must.

When that which we call Christianity, or perhaps more properly life in God, has become—not a heavy burden which we laboriously drag along with us—but our happiness, the hidden source of our life’s joy, then it is, both for the individual and for the congregation, a natural inward need to labor that others also may be brought to share in this life and this happiness.

It is also both right and natural that in this work we should think first and foremost of our own people. The first Christian missionaries were commanded to begin at home, “beginning from Jerusalem.”

Life in God Jesus himself has described as the greatest happiness, indeed as blessedness. And he has compared it to a treasure which is worth so much that everything ought to be sold in order that one may come into possession of it.

And this treasure is unlike earthly treasures. These—if we obtain any of them—we would rather keep for ourselves. But not this treasure. It is sufficient, it is great enough not merely for some of us, but for all, all.

And it has this peculiar quality, that the more we give out of it to others, the more we ourselves have remaining. Never is our peace with God deeper, our joy, our life in him richer than when, perhaps without sparing ourselves, we labor to help our brothers and sisters find the “treasure” and come to possess it.

Perhaps one or another of you who read these words has experienced that it is so.

Or was it not so, that on the days when you most earnestly and tirelessly used your strength in your Master’s service, resolved to go on his errand, then you knew in your heart something

of that peace which surpasses all understanding, and which Jesus promises to his own?

And on the other hand, when you “spared yourself,” were unwilling to do anything for the Lord, and neglected your opportunities, did you not then experience that the heart became troubled and the soul without peace?

And as it is with the individual believer, so also with the congregation. The congregation which concerns itself only with itself and its own “edification” will languish and lose its strength and the blessing of God.

To the question why we attempt to carry on home mission work, I believe that most of those for whom life in God has become a blessed reality will answer: We carry on home mission because we must.

This work has become an impelling necessity for us, insofar as we are from time to time permitted to believe that we ourselves belong to the Lord.

Paul speaks of how “the love of Christ compels.”

God grant us much of this love which “compels.” Then also the work which we call our home mission will be done with joy and willingness.

4 A Little from Our District Meeting

“Folkebladet,” November 29, 1916

Pastor Joh. Skonnord began with the sermon. His subject was the Christian hope. Among other things, he said that it was a great riches to possess the hope that does not put to shame, because God’s love has been poured out in our hearts.

The subject for discussion, Luke 10:23–37, was introduced by Pastor Gustav Sandanger of Vattle Læke. It was easy to understand that the speaker had devoted much labor to the introductory address he gave, and it was especially well suited to lead us into the thoughts of the text. To “introduce” a word of God, or any other subject for Christian discussion, is a very difficult matter, which few are able to accomplish. I myself have felt the difficulty very keenly when I have had the task of giving such an introduction. Pastor Sandanger made a very good attempt at introducing the word of God before us. The sum of his thoughts concerning this passage of Scripture seemed to me capable of being formulated thus: Neither belonging to God’s people, nor having religious experiences, nor possessing orthodox views of the way of salvation avails unto salvation, but a life whose task is to show mercy.

When Jesus spoke these words, he had before his mind’s eye a people of God who were zealous for good works.

During the discussion of this word of God, several emphasized that the condition for coming into possession of a Samaritan disposition was to be permitted to “see Jesus”: “Blessed are the eyes that see what you see,” Jesus says to his disciples.

During the discussion, in which many of the pastors present took part, the importance of

being permitted to “see Jesus” was emphasized with great force: to see him in the way the disciples saw him, as the Savior of the world, their Savior.

If I were to point to something that seemed to me to have been neglected at the district meeting, I would mention that little was said about the man who had fallen among robbers. In other words, it seemed to me that too little was said about mission, home mission, and mission to the heathen. There was, however, one of the pastors who spoke briefly, in passing, about home or inner mission. He emphasized how important it is for our congregations to support this work and to make it possible to labor with the Word of God among our people who live in the newly settled districts and who there are exposed to the danger of forgetting their soul and their God. It is my firm conviction that this district meeting will bear some fruit for several of those who attended it.

Since the secretary is publishing a complete report of the meeting, I shall pass over the details. I believe it would be a great blessing to the life of the congregations if every district in the Free Church, at one of its district meetings, could take up our common undertakings: Augsburg, the missions, and the work of mercy.

E. B.

5 Joy in Heaven

(Luke 15:7)

“Folkebladet,” July 04, 1917

The question concerning God cannot readily be torn out of the human soul. Perhaps this comes entirely from the fact that it has come forth from God, created by him. Certainly it may be pressed back by other questions and interests, but it comes again—often strongly and irresistibly.

And what is it that we desire to know? What is there in the question concerning God that is so important for us helpless children of men to have made clear?

Yes, it is this: whether he cares for us, whether he has a loving heart toward us. And until we gain certainty upon this question, we shall never have peace. You who happen to read these words know that this is so. Nothing among all the earthly goods and gifts and earthly happiness you have attained can wholly satisfy you. Your soul longs for something more. And what is it? The answer is: God. Or perhaps more exactly: the certainty of being loved by God.

Am I, little and wretched as I am, evil and sinful as I am—am I loved by God? This is the fundamental question of life at the depth of the human heart, and upon this question I must have an answer. Who can give the answer? Other human beings? O yes, there are people who out of blessed experience can tell us that they know themselves to be loved by God, to have received grace, to be saved. It does us good to meet such people and to listen to their confession. But—it is not enough for me. For these people can be mistaken. Mistaken about

God and about themselves. And what they tell me may rest upon a self-assumed delusion or something of that kind.

Is there, then, anyone who can give me an answer so certain and secure that I may dare to trust it, live upon it—die upon it?

Yes, there is. He who speaks in the Bible verse from which the heading of this little piece is taken—he can give an answer—an answer upon which I can rely in life and in death.

And he can give an answer because he knows God as no one else does. “The only-begotten Son, who is in the Father’s bosom, he has made him known.”

He gives his answer to the burning question of the human heart, whether God loves us, out of his own intimate fellowship and knowledge of his Father.

And his answer is this: “God so loved the world that he gave his Son!”

His answer is this: “I say to you: In the same way there will be joy in heaven over one sinner who repents!”

God is love, Jesus says. Thus we have received an answer to the question whether God cares for us. Jesus, his only-begotten Son, says: He loves us—loves, loves so that he gave his Son—gave him to the world, gave him to me!

Glorious truth! Blessed assurance: God is my Father.

I belong with him. And this Father does not forget his child—not even when the child forgets him—goes his own way and comes into misery.

This is the gospel. And the gospel is what the mission seeks to have proclaimed to as many as possible. The gospel is also what our Home Mission desires to have proclaimed to our people throughout the great cities and in the many new settlements where our people are building their homes.

You who happen to read this, will you do your part so that the gospel may be proclaimed to our people? Perhaps you yourself are so blessed as to know that for your sake there has been “joy in heaven”—when, repentant and bowed down, you stood before your God with this prayer: “Father, I have sinned!” and through the gospel received the assurance of full forgiveness of all sin. And is not this assurance the most glorious, the best of all?

O, so many of your brothers and sisters are going about in the world with a soul wounded by the arrow that came from the enemy. The gospel alone can heal the soul’s burning wounds—will you take part in sending it to our people?

At this time, throughout our whole country, collections are being made for “The Red Cross.” What is the purpose? To relieve bodily distress, to lessen pain and misery. Certainly a blessed work! But there is something in the world worse than bodily distress. You know this, my brother and sister, who in deep anguish of soul, in fear and trembling, have stood bowed before God in shame and sorrow over your sin. Everything else in the world seemed so insignificant to you then in comparison with the question of salvation, grace, mercy. And you know this also, that all the other joys and goods you possessed became small in comparison with what

you felt, and still feel, when you were permitted to look into the Father's heart, God's great, warm, compassionate Father's heart, and were enabled to believe that all is forgiven, all sin blotted out, remitted. Then you became glad in the midst of sorrow, rich in the midst of poverty, happy in the hardest adversity. And this happiness became yours through the gospel, the message of salvation from sin and death through Jesus Christ. Therefore I will repeat it: take part in sending the gospel out to our people in this country and in Canada! It is needed more than ever before that the message of God's love for sinners sound forth clearly and in full voice. The time is troubled and difficult, and in many there is stirring a deep longing for something secure and steadfast to cling to:

"Where does my heart find its most blessed rest? With Jesus, only with Jesus! Where is found the firm-founded rock for faith? With Jesus, yes, only with Jesus!"

My brother and sister, do what you can so that our people may be led to Jesus! Will you?

E. B.

6 Your Father is Merciful

Luke 6:36

"Folkebladet," July 18, 1917

There is a glorious consolation in this word of Jesus for you who have learned to know yourself and have discovered that you are a sinner, a great sinner, who by disobedience and wickedness has made yourself deserving of God's wrath and punishment.

Luther gives himself and all of us a dreadful verdict in the Second Article: "lost and condemned to eternal death." But is this verdict true? Can things really be so bad with us? Does the verdict fit us, fit you? Yes, it does! It is true what you and I have sung so many times:

"My sin is great and grievous quite, from it my sorrows spring!"

But if the matter stands thus, that my sin, your sin against the living God, is so great and exposes you and me to his wrath and punishment, then this is a good word from Jesus: "Your Father is merciful."

In our explanation, the question of what God's mercy is receives this answer: "He has pity upon our misery."

It is a beautiful answer, deep and true as far as it reaches. But it scarcely reaches far enough—that is, if we try to explain God's pity from ordinary human relations. For human beings too can have pity upon one another and upon one another's need and misery. But often it goes no further than "having pity," or feeling sympathy and fellow-feeling with those whose need and misery we know. And why? Ah, partly because we stand powerless and helpless when the question becomes one of helping in the need, and partly because we are so often unwilling to make the sacrifice required of us if the need and misery of our fellow human beings, our brothers and sisters, is to be relieved and remedied.

With the Father, however, it is otherwise. He does not merely “have pity upon our misery”; he does not sit up there in his heaven and blessedness feeling sorry for us who are in misery and need, without being able and without being willing to remedy our deep misery. No, he is not like that. He possesses the power and the will by which he is able to save in the midst of misery. And he uses this power and this will.

“Then God in eternity had pity upon this great distress of mine; he remembered his mercy and willed to provide me help. He turned a fatherly mind toward me, and then, without deceit, gave forth the dearest thing that he possessed.”

“Your Father is merciful.”

Ah, you who long to find firm and secure ground upon which to build in life and in death—here it is: God’s mercy. “The eternal and incomprehensible One has unveiled the features of his face to us. This face is called Christ. With fathomless compassion Christ’s eternity-deep eyes look upon us. We know his compassion: ‘Though he was rich, for our sake he became poor, so that through his poverty we might become rich.’”

“O abyss! which all our sins has swallowed and put to death through Jesus’ death, and sends us only to repentance, that we may find grace sweet. Here Jesus’ bloody sweat cries out: Mercy! Mercy!”

Yes, we surely think this word of Jesus is good: “Your Father is merciful.” Our hope, our salvation, our life are contained in it. Thanks be to God!

But—Jesus says something more: “Be merciful!” A command, an order from Jesus, then. And to whom? To all, all who know that they need “the Father’s” mercy. And commands, orders, we are not always fond of. Not even Jesus’ commands. Submit yourself, and you will see that it is so. But Jesus has said it, and he expects us at least to try to obey him.

What does he mean when he says: “Be merciful”? He means that we are to have pity upon the misery in which our brothers and sisters in the world are placed. And there is still so much misery, temporal and spiritual. And Jesus wills that this misery should go to our hearts, so that we are drawn by it and driven to do what we can to relieve it.

For he says: “Be merciful as your Father.”

Brothers and sisters, is our mercy akin to the Father’s? Ah, I am so afraid that many of us must lower our eyes in shame and answer, humiliating though it is: No.

Of the Father’s mercy we sing:

“The thought soon came to him that the world must perish; it cut him to the heart. In such heartfelt love he came down to us upon the earth to relieve our pain.”

Such is his mercy. But ours? Does the thought cut us to the heart that many of our own people in this land live “without God and without hope”? Not only those who with deliberate intent have torn themselves away from God and chosen to live in rebellion against him, but the many who are deceived by sin and by the beguiling influence of the world, and who grieve over it and long for peace. It is surely true that there are many who go about with “secret

weeping of the heart.” And here Jesus expects us to be merciful, to have pity upon them—yes, with such compassion as the Father’s, whose sacrifice was his only Son.

Yes, how far we still are from the goal! But let our recognition of this not tempt us to despondency, but rather to “press on to take hold of it because we have been taken hold of by Christ.”

Where, then, or in what way, can more of this self-sacrificing mercy become ours? I think I will answer: by looking long, long into the face of the merciful Father, deep, deep into the dying eyes of the rejected Savior, and remembering that it is he who says to us: “Be merciful!” I know it will help. Your heart will be enlarged to contain more of that compassion which drives you to fervent intercession also for the salvation of our own people, and drives you to send your gift to our home mission.

Be merciful—as your Father!

E. B.

7 Where Can Anyone Get Bread?

Mark 8:1

“Folkebladet,” August 01, 1917

There is much anxiety contained in this question. Many are those who, with anguished hearts and tear-filled or, still worse, tearless eyes, have asked in this way. And many are still those who ask this anxious question. Those who formed the question in the biblical passage from which the heading of this little piece is taken addressed it to Jesus, the Savior. And we know that with him help was to be found.

It is rather interesting to notice how Jesus regarded human bodily distress and need. His first miracle was to remove the embarrassment of a poor bridal couple. And we know that on several occasions he showed that he “was deeply moved with compassion” for the people because of their bodily distress. And as he was, so he still is. “Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today, yes, forever!”

It is good to remember this also in the serious time in which we live, and in which the question, “Where can anyone get bread?” becomes very pressing for many. He still has the heart that “is deeply moved with compassion” for those who suffer bodily hunger, or who in some other way are oppressed by sorrow and anxiety. And he still possesses the power that enables him to feed the hungry and to comfort the sorrowful and unhappy.

Go, therefore, with the many anxious questions that stir within your soul to Jesus. With him help is to be found, peace and rest to be found. Say to God with childlike confidence:

“Care, O dear Father, you! I will not be anxious, nor with a troubled mind ask about my future. Care for me throughout my time, care for me and mine! God, almighty, gracious, gentle, care for all who are yours!

Care when I go to rest and my eye closes. Care when I rise again and hasten to my work! Care thus for my calling and station, hand and mouth and heart, for the work that I can do, for my joy and pain!”

If Jesus had lived bodily among us, he would surely have wished to teach us the same thing that through his Word he will teach us: to live a simple and frugal life. He feeds the hungry crowds there in the wilderness, it is true. But he feeds them with bread and fish—and nothing more. Thus, not so many dishes, so many kinds of food as are now so commonly used, but which are in no way necessary in order to eat one’s fill. And he would teach us to “gather the remnants so that nothing is wasted.” In our time there is a boundless amount that “goes to waste,” and we greatly need to learn from Jesus to take care of what remains and to learn contentment with little.

Besides this, he will teach us to “give thanks.” It is written that Jesus “took the seven loaves and gave thanks.” He therefore prayed at table. There are many who do not do this, including many of our Scandinavian people in this country. In this respect they do not resemble him whose name they nevertheless bear and wish to bear. More than once I have found myself deeply grieved that even such young people as have come from Christian homes, where prayer at table is regularly offered by both parents and children, as soon as they have been out among strangers, cease to do as Jesus did: “give thanks.”

Why? Ah, because “the others” do not do it; the Americans do not do it; it is not refined enough. And when these same young people come home to father and mother, where prayer is still offered at the table, they are ashamed to fold their hands and join their praying parents in the table prayer. I would like to be permitted to say to young and old: let us do as Jesus did—give thanks for our daily bread and ask the Lord to bless it for us.

Besides this, Jesus will teach us in this Word that he desires it, wills it, that his children, his people, are to help God feed others, just as the disciples helped Jesus give food to the people.

This still applies. And it applies not only in the question of food for the body. It applies especially in the question of that food by which the soul may be filled and live.

Jesus Christ wills that we should always carry the picture of our poor brother’s need and distress in our soul, so that we are driven to share with him:

“Up, brothers, hasten—the life is short! Much should be done, but so little is done. Many are those who wait—those who give are but few; enough there is for the great, but so little for the small. Wipe the tear away, brothers, wipe tears away! Life is short from our cradle to grave. The Lord, he waits; we are to follow in his footsteps; God will bless everyone who blesses his brother!”

And here I must then mention our home mission. Those who have been appointed to care for it often ask in deep anxiety: “Where can anyone get bread?” when our workers do not receive their support, when the mission treasury is empty, when the debt grows, and when little or nothing comes in by way of gifts for this work. The Mission Board also tries to take this anxious question to Jesus. But when he answers now as then, “How many loaves do you have?” he does not say this only to us who have been appointed to direct the work of our

home mission, but he says it to all of you—and also to you, my brother and sister, who read this.

And what shall we answer him? I know what we can answer him if only we are willing: We have enough bread for the need, provided it is distributed with Jesus' blessing upon it, if only we are willing to distribute it to those who are in need.

It is written that Jesus "gave them to his disciples so that they should set them before the people." They were not merely to have the bread for themselves—they were to distribute it to the people.

Yes, my brother and sister, do you understand what Jesus would have you do? You have bread—food and drink and God's saving Word—in abundance. Distribute it to your poor, needy, hungry brothers! There is blessing in it.

E. B.

8 The Samaritan

Luke 10:23–37

"Folkebladet," September 19, 1917

The last part of today's Gospel is very well known, namely, the account of the Good Samaritan. Jesus told this event to the man who asked: "What shall I do to inherit eternal life?"

There is, as everyone will see, a considerable amount of Law in Jesus' answer to this man. And many do not like the preaching of Law, or, if you will, of morality, works. Look and see, and you will be astonished at how often he speaks of works. We are so accustomed to the question of how one is to be saved being answered, "Believe in Jesus," that we are almost startled when some other answer is given.

"Keep the commandments, and you shall live," says Jesus. And concerning the day of judgment, of which Jesus speaks in Matthew 25, he says that what is decisive as to who shall be placed at the King's right hand or at his left is their works, what they have done or neglected to do.

How are we to understand this? Does Jesus teach another way of salvation than, for example, Paul, and than the one ordinarily preached in our services?

Oh no, surely he does not. He himself has said as plainly as possible: "The one who believes in me has eternal life." "Whoever believes and is baptized shall be saved," and there are many other such words of his.

The different answers to the question of salvation do not stand in conflict with one another. There is complete agreement between them. For why are we to believe in Jesus? Many will answer this question: We are to believe in Jesus in order to escape perdition—to avoid going to hell. But this answer is hardly the right one. When the angel told Mary that she was to become the mother of the Savior of the world, he said: "You shall call his name Jesus, for he shall save his people from their sins!"

We are therefore to receive Jesus, to believe in him, in order to be set free from sin and enabled to keep God's commandments.

Paul expresses it thus: God sent his Son and condemned sin in the flesh, *in order that the requirement of the Law might be fulfilled in us.*

There are many who seem to understand matters as though, provided only that one believes in Jesus and comforts oneself with his atoning death, one will be admitted into the blessedness of heaven, whether one has been willing to keep the commandments, to love God and to love one's neighbor, or not. But this is self-deception, and it is against this kind of self-deception that Jesus so often and so insistently speaks.

In heaven or on earth there is no blessedness to be attained without goodness: "Blessed are the pure in heart, for they shall see God," says Jesus. And Jesus will give us that pure heart when we give ourselves over to him without reserve, body and soul. And this is to believe in him:

"The faith that Jesus embraces and that can cleanse the heart, the faith by which one reaches heaven's land of joy, that faith is strong, and must bring all the world beneath it, in sorrow and in gladness be able to endure its trial!"

These two who passed by the fallen and wounded man, although they *saw him* and the distress he was in, were doubtless both well satisfied in the consciousness that they possessed "the right faith."

What, then, was it that they lacked, and that Jesus says we must have if it is to be well with us eternally?

It was the disposition that has compassion upon distress and desires to relieve it, the disposition that has compassion *because it loves.* The Good Samaritan possessed that disposition, and therefore he helped the man who had fallen among robbers. The Samaritan's love, goodness of heart, and compassion drove him to show mercy toward the fallen man although he was a Jew, a political and religious opponent.

As Jesus said to the man who asked for the way to life, "Go, and do likewise," so he says to us. We never attain the goal of our life, which is *God himself,* by having the right understanding of Jesus' saving work and holding that understanding to be true. Many think so, but are grievously mistaken. It does not avail for salvation unless it is able to *change our disposition and our life.*

The goal of our life is attained only by our being transformed more and more to *become like God,* becoming merciful through that love and power in the heart which "is poured out into our hearts through the Holy Spirit who has been given to us." The question that, according to today's Gospel, is so important is not this: "Can I have a blessed death?" But this: "*Do I have the Samaritan disposition?*"

There are sincere souls who become afraid of themselves at this question and who, with shame and sorrow, must answer: I have so little of this disposition. And such persons are not *satisfied* to have so little. They long for more.

How can we obtain more of this disposition? I will answer: *By becoming glad.* Become more glad, and you will become more merciful, more good. And how can I become more glad?

There is, indeed, so much here that is fitted to make us sorrowful: anxiety for ourselves, anxiety for those dear to us, anxiety for the future, and more of the same kind.

Oh, my brother and sister, *God* can make you glad. He does it *through his Word:*

“Whatever here in the world may grieve my soul, with *Jesus and the Word* it always turns out well. I do not always feel and know my happiness; yet in faith upon the Word my soul has peace. Oh, blessed rest: to believe in Jesus and have God’s Word dwelling within!”

“When life grows dark, when anxious I and weak, I hasten to the Word, and there it becomes day. When others are rich and I am not as they, I sit within the Word, and *there I am rich.* Oh, blessed rest: to believe in Jesus and have God’s Word dwelling within!”

In his Word the Lord says to us: Go to Christ as you are—as helpless and sinful as you feel yourself to be—and you receive righteousness and peace with God, and *then you become glad—blessed.* “Blessed is the one whose transgression is forgiven, whose sin is covered.”

But this deep peace of God in Christ, which surpasses all understanding, is not a peace in which to idle, a peace of *inactivity.* No, it is working peace, peace for working with willingness and zeal, working in our heavenly Father’s great vineyard. We do not measure our children’s love for us first and chiefly by their words about how dearly they love father and mother, but by *their willingness to serve and obey us.* So does God also.

“We have been created a second time, in Christ, for good works which God himself has prepared for us, that we should walk in them.” And there is enough to do in our heavenly Father’s vineyard. Enough for everyone. There is the foreign mission. And there is the home mission. So many of our brothers and sisters in the world have “fallen among robbers.” And many of them you and I see. Shall we do as the two did: *pass by? Or shall we have compassion and help,* even though this costs both *trouble* and—*money?*

Oh, my brother and sister, you who have had your feet set upon the rock and who are permitted to go about here in this world of sorrow with the blessed assurance in your heart of your right and standing as a child of God—*work for the Lord!* You have the opportunity. Use it. Let it be evident in your conduct that you not only look forward to “a blessed death,” but *rejoice in the lifelong work for your own salvation and that of your brothers!*

Do not let your Christianity consist in *having things well,* you and your own, while you close your heart against the great, crying need around you! No, let it *drive you and constrain you to action and sacrifice!* Learn from him who, in love for you, sacrificed *all*—sacrificed every drop of blood, for you, *for me!* Amen.

E. B.